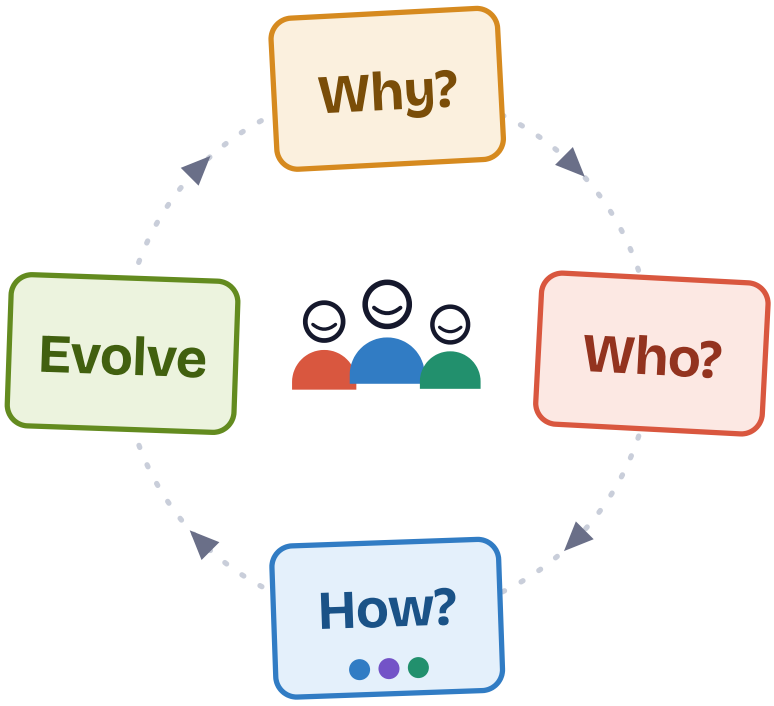
Form your team

Six conversations every team needs, in any order, captured on one canvas.

Offline workbook · Print the pages you need, one conversation at a time or all at once.



By Michael Heider · formyourteam.dk

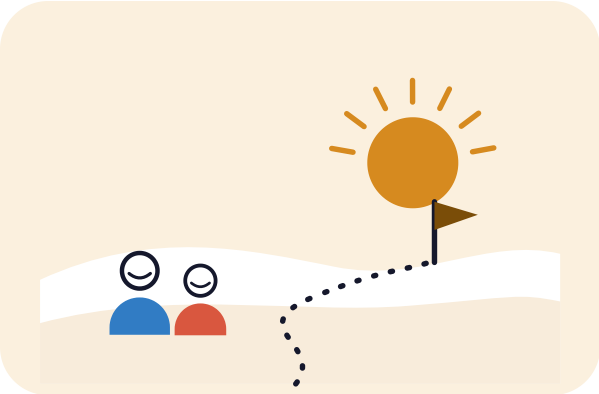
How to use this workbook

1. **Pick a conversation.** Start where your team needs it most. The order is up to you.
2. **Read the key questions out loud.** They frame what the conversation is for.
3. **Run the exercise.** Each one has steps a facilitator can read out, and a worksheet to write on.
4. **Capture what you agree on the Team Canvas** at the back of this workbook.
5. **Revisit it.** Every six to twelve weeks, and whenever someone joins or leaves, the purpose shifts or responsibilities change.

The six conversations

- **Why are we here?** Purpose, beneficiaries and a shared picture of success.
- **Who are we?** Strengths, working preferences and personal connection.
- **How do we work?** The team's practical operating rhythm.
- **How do we make decisions?** Clarity about autonomy, participation and accountability.
- **How do we want to be together?** A practical team contract.
- **How do we learn and reform?** Keep the team canvas alive.

Prefer working on screen? The same exercises run at formyourteam.dk, where answers save in your browser and turn into a canvas automatically.



Why

Why are we here?

Purpose, beneficiaries and a shared picture of success.

Key questions

? Who benefits from our work?

? What difference should the team make for them?

? What would meaningful success look like?

Exercises

Explain it to a friend · Pairs, then whole team · 25 min

In three years' time… · Individual, then whole team · 30 min

Explain it to a friend

Why are we here? · Pairs, then whole team · 25 min

Find plain, human words for why the team exists, before anyone writes a mission statement.

How to run it

1. In pairs, imagine explaining the team's reason for being to a friend over dinner. Speak naturally and avoid organisational language.
2. The listener does not correct or debate. They capture phrases that feel clear, human and meaningful.
3. Switch roles, then compare what was consistent and what was different.
4. Use the strongest language to create a shared purpose statement.

Worksheet

We exist to...

We do this for...

We do this by...



In three years' time...

Why are we here? · Individual, then whole team · 30 min

Agree one picture of success that feels true to everyone, and the early signs that it is happening.

How to run it

1. Each person completes: "In three years' time, this team will have..." Create two or three versions individually.
2. Share without discussion and group similar ideas.
3. Vote for the statement that most unites the team and feels true, not merely the most ambitious.
4. Refine it together and identify two or three signs that would show it is becoming real.

Worksheet

In three years' time, this team will have...

We will know this is becoming real when...



Who

Who are we?

Strengths, working preferences and personal connection.

Key questions

? What does each person bring?

? How do we each work at our best?

? What should teammates know about us beyond our role?

Exercises

The story behind me · Whole team · 3–4 min per person

Personal user manual · Individual, then share in pairs · 20 min

Skills marketplace · Individual, then whole team · 30 min

The story behind me

Who are we? · Whole team · 3–4 min per person

Build personal connection through one small, chosen story each.

How to run it

1. Each person brings one photograph or object that says something important about them.
2. They tell the story behind it and why they chose it.
3. Listeners ask curious questions without analysing or interpreting the story.

Nothing to fill in here. This is about getting to know each other and building trust before the next exercises.

Personal user manual

Who are we? · Individual, then share in pairs · 20 min

Make working preferences explicit, so teammates don't have to guess.

How to run it

1. Each person completes their own card on their own, in their own words.
2. Share in pairs. The listener asks one question to understand better, not to challenge.
3. Bring one surprising or useful insight back to the whole team.

Worksheet

You get the best from me when...

I struggle when...

I prefer feedback that...

Under pressure I may...

Some of my quirks are...

You can rely on me for...

Skills marketplace

Who are we? · Individual, then whole team · 30 min

See what the team can offer each other and where it wants to grow.

How to run it

1. Each person fills in their own stall: three things they can offer the team, and one thing they want to grow in.
2. Go round the room. Each person reads their stall out loud in a minute or two.
3. Look at who could learn from whom, and agree one pairing to try in the next few weeks.

Worksheet

Three skills or strengths I offer

One capability I want to develop



Rhythm

How do we work?

The team's practical operating rhythm.

Key questions

- ? When do we plan, make and review?
- ? Which meetings and habits actually help us, and which can go?
- ? What should we do together, and what can happen on our own time?

Exercises

Draw your team's loop · Whole team, at a whiteboard · 30 min

Draw your team's loop

How do we work? · Whole team, at a whiteboard · 30 min

Agree a simple rhythm for planning, making and reviewing.

How to run it

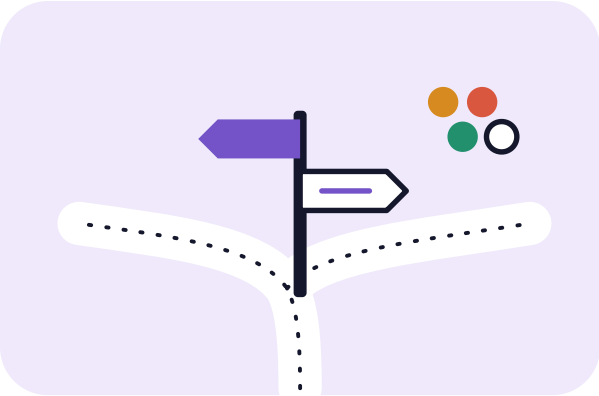
1. Draw a loop: plan → make → review → back to plan.
2. Put the meetings and habits you already have on the loop. Keep what helps, drop what doesn't.
3. For each of the three moments, agree when and how it happens, and write it above.
4. Try the rhythm for one working cycle, then adjust it together.

Worksheet

When do we plan?

When do we make?

When do we review?



Decision making

How do we make decisions?

Clarity about autonomy, participation and accountability.

Key questions

- ? Which decisions can individuals make?
- ? Which decisions need input or shared ownership?
- ? Which ways of deciding could we try?

Exercises

Choose how to decide · Whole team · 30 min

Choose how to decide

How do we make decisions? · Whole team · 30 min

Pick one important decision you make often, and choose a way to make it next time.

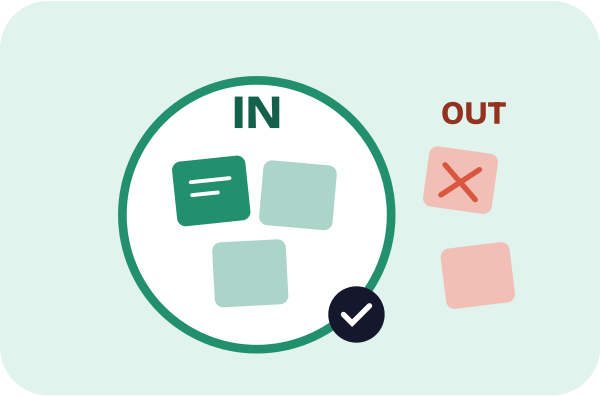
How to run it

1. Each person names decisions that come up again and again. Agree on one that matters to the team.
2. Read the twelve ways to decide together. Ask what this decision needs: narrowing options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say.
3. Choose one way and try it the next few times the decision comes up.
4. Talk about how it felt, and whether to keep it or try another.

Worksheet

A decision we make often

The way we'll try to decide



Team values

How do we want to be together?

A practical team contract.

Key questions

? What behaviour helps us do our best work?

? What behaviour is not acceptable in this team?

? How will we hold ourselves and each other accountable?

Exercises

The two-circle team contract · Whole team · 45 min

The two-circle team contract

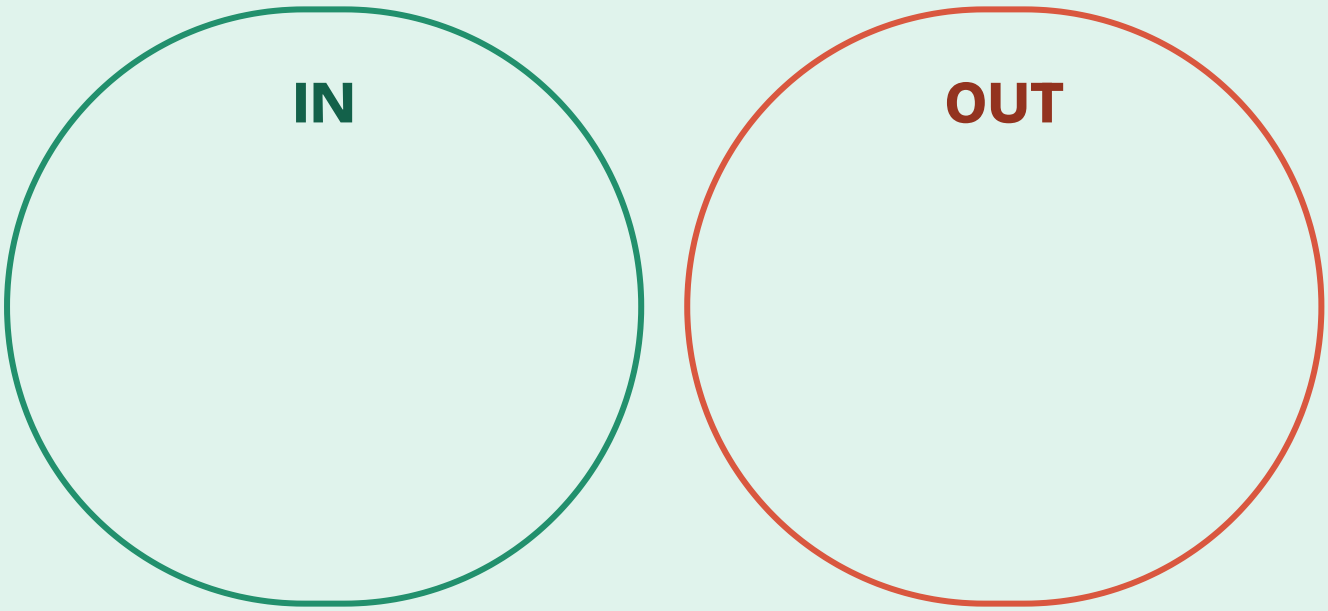
How do we want to be together? · Whole team · 45 min

Agree, in plain words, the behaviours that belong in this team and the ones that don't.

How to run it

1. Draw two large circles and label them IN and OUT.
2. Add behaviours to IN that the team wants to practise and protect.
3. Add behaviours to OUT that undermine trust, inclusion or good work.
4. Talk them through, combine similar ones, and rewrite them as things someone could actually see.

Worksheet





Evolve

How do we learn and reform?

Keep the team canvas alive.

Key questions

- ? What should we protect?
- ? What is no longer serving the team?
- ? What change should trigger a team reset?

Exercises

Keep / Change / Try · Whole team · 30 min



Keep / Change / Try

How do we learn and reform? · Whole team · 30 min

Decide what to protect, what to let go and what small experiment to run next.

How to run it

1. Keep: What about this team should we protect?
2. Change: What is no longer helping us?
3. Try: What small experiment will we run next?
4. Choose a review date. Recommend revisiting one part of the canvas every six to twelve weeks and whenever membership, purpose or responsibilities change.

Worksheet

Keep: what should we protect?

Change: what is no longer helping us?

Try: what small experiment will we run next?

We will revisit this on…

We will reset the canvas when…

Our Team Canvas

Team _____ Date _____ Next review _____

Our purpose

? Why do we exist?
? Who do we do this for, and how?

Our future

? What does success look like in three years?
? How will we know it is becoming real?

Our people

? What does each person bring?
? What do we want to develop?
? How do we each work at our best?

Our rhythm

? When do we plan, make and review?
? What do we do together, and what on our own time?

Our decision making

? Which decision do we make often?
? Which way of deciding will we try?

Our team values

? What behaviour helps us do our best work (IN), and what is not acceptable (OUT)?

IN

OUT

Our next evolution

? What will we keep, change and try?
? When do we look at this canvas again?